

SAFARI

The LIONESS prowls in with a feline grace. They address the audience as if they are the pride of lions who have shunned them.

LIONESS

(Growl)

Roar. Don't look at me like that. I know what the safari says. They call me a monster. Like all lioness. Nature says that a lioness who does not hunt her meat, but washes their ears, has lost her mind.

Lioness crouches, with their eyes tracking a calf in the front row.

LIONESS

But look at this baby antelope. This little... foster. My first. They were shivering in the shade. Their mother ran... I do not blame her, I have a face like a nightmare... but the calf stayed. They looked at me and did not see a predator. They saw a shadow to hide in.

Lioness approaches an audience member.

LIONESS

You. Hold your hands out. Softly. That's how I had to carry him. Not with teeth to eat, but with gums of fun. Tell me: if you are born to destroy, but choose to guard, are you still a monster? Or are you finally a mother?

Lioness waits for a brief answer.

LIONESS

(Nodding)

The biologists, they sat in their Jeeps and scribbled in notebooks. "Lioness," they called me. "The Blessed One." They watched me starve because I would not leave my foster to hunt. I grew thin so he could grow tall.

Then came my second foster calf. Then third. Six times the Great Spirit sent me a child with hooves instead of claws. Each time, the same story: the hunger in my belly screaming to eat them, and the heart in my chest telling me to feed them.

Lioness points to different sections of the audience.

LIONESS

You over there... you leopards. Snarling in the dark. And you- you hyenas, waiting for me to sleep. I need help. Everyone, make the sound of the dry wind. Low and steady.

Lioness stands center, arms spread wide as if shielding a small huddle.

LIONESS

I fought the big males. I took scars on my flanks to keep my monsters safe. People think motherhood is a soft thing, all milk and licking. No. Motherhood is a war. It is a choice you make every sunrise: Today, nothing dies on my watch.

The wind fades. Lioness drops their arms, looking weary but peaceful.

LIONESS

However, the wild took them eventually. A mother lion cannot outrun the law of the bush forever. But for those weeks, the lions and the antelopes slept in the same dust.

Lioness leans in close to an audience member.

LIONESS

If you had to protect something that was supposed to be your enemy... would you have the courage to be a monster like me?

Lioness turns, walking slowly towards the back of the stage. They pause, looking over their shoulder with a regal gaze.

LIONESS

I am the Lioness. I am the Blessed. And I am still hungry... but only for the peace of the nursery.

JEEP

An observer, wearing a field vest and clutching a notebook, looks out with binoculars.

OBSERVER

Six times. Six times she chose starvation over the kill. I've spent twenty years tracking the panthera leo across the Samburu. I know their biology. I know the calory required to maintain a hundred-and-fifty-kilo predator. By all laws of nature, she should be dead.

The observer paces, looking at a few audience members.

OBSERVER

You. If I took away your grocery store, your kitchen, DoorDash... and I handed you a sandwich. But then, I put a shivering baby deer next to you that needed that sandwich to survive. How many days before your stomach overrides your soul?

The data says day three. By day four, the instinct to survive drowns out everything else. But she... that Lioness is just messed up.

The observer moves into the aisle, pointing to an audience member's hands.

OBSERVER

Look at your hands. We call this *nurturing*. We see it as a soft, mammalian trait. But in the bush, motherhood is a mathematical error. It's an investment of energy with no guaranteed return.

(to another audience member)

Help me with a calculation. Tell me a number: how many scars is one life worth? If you had to take a hit from a leopard to save something that wasn't even your own kind... what's the limit?

The observer listens, then sighs, closing the notebook with a heavy thud.

OBSERVER

The Blessed One. We gave her that name cause she has no explanation to be.

(MORE)

OBSERVER (CONT'D)

We keep looking for that motherhood gene, that oxytocin spike, that biological trigger. But maybe it's not a trigger. Maybe it's a double-edged sword.

The observer looks towards the back of the stage where Lioness exited.

OBSERVER

She is no monster like the rest of the lions. She's a monster because she broke the only law the world has: Eat or be eaten.

The observer looks back at the audience.

OBSERVER

I'm starting to think being a mother and being a predator are no different. Based on my observations, I came here to study a lioness. I think I'm just studying a miracle.

The observer steps on a centipede.

OBSERVER

Oh crap... I just stepped on a centipede. A mother centipede. She was feeding her babies. Oh, you don't wanna know. There's a process called matrophagy. Okay, long story short: the mother lets her babies eat her insides out. Well, it's no different than what you mothers do anyways... Against, we're around miracles.

MOTHER OF GOD